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Culture (OWC): [Gikuyu \(FL10\)](#)

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Sub Region: Eastern Africa

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Section Title(S)

3 Wanjiku: The Life of a Traditional Woman

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After *Uhuru*, my sons went back to their schooling. The oldest one—the one who stays at Kagumo Teacher's College—he has gone up through Form Six and has even gone abroad. The other two finished Form Four [secondary level]. One works in the coffee factory as an inspector and the other was just appointed an assistant chief.

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How is schooling different nowadays from when my sons went to school? The level of schooling my sons acquired was the highest one could go then. But today, people are not satisfied with four years of secondary school—that has become the lowest level of schooling that people want to achieve, because a good job requires more schooling now. But people today—those with a Form Four education—do not want to stay in r ural areas like this. They want to work in a town. Also, we who are older can have trouble from children who attend

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school because sometimes they can abuse somebody who is not schooled—even an older person like a parent! Long ago, when I was growing up, nobody dared to abuse somebody in an older *riika*. Today, you can see boys and girls of different age groups mixing and even joking with one another. The importance of *mariika* in Agĩkũyũ tradition has disappeared with schooling.

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There is no use taking a boy to school nowadays and leaving a girl behind, because girls who have been to school are more helpful to the family than boys who've been to school. Why? Girls help their brothers and sisters acquire the things they need—even school fees—with the money they earn from a good job after completing school, but a boy may move to the city and forget about his family.

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When Kamau was working at Voi and I used to receive letters from him, I wished then I had gone to school so I could read the letters without anybody reading them for me. But just because we couldn't read, didn't mean we didn't think. Before there were schools, we thought a lot, but in different ways. When a person was sick, the *mũndũ mugo* had to think out the cause of the disease and make a cure. When one saw she was pregnant, she used to tie knots on a string from the day she had sexual relations to the day she gave birth to keep track of time. When counting cows or goats, men used sticks to represent their property so they could keep track of the number of animals. Young children had the responsibility of keeping track of all the cows and goats when they went herding, and sometimes the father would test them to make sure they knew which were his from those of the neighbors. We exercised our minds with riddles and songs. The one solving a riddle had to have knowledge of Agĩkũyũ customs and the surroundings [environment]. Unless you know our traditions and the way we live, you cannot solve the riddles. So we had a different way of thinking that did not use books. Sometimes, I experiment by thinking—I see what and how others do something like building a new house and I remember how they did it, then come back here and try to do the same from what I can remember. That way I am able to learn new things.

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